

APPENDIX I

As an aid to the reader who may wish to sample one of the earliest examples of the Japanese art of fiction, I include here, with the kind permission of Donald Keene, his new translation of the Taketori monogatari (The Tale of the Bamboo Cutter), a tale discussed in Chapter IV of the present study.

Taketori monogatari (The Tale of the Bamboo Cutter)

Translated by Donald Keene*

Many years ago there lived a man they called the Old Bamboo Cutter. Every day he would make his way into the fields and mountains to gather bamboo, which he fashioned into all manner of wares. His name was Sanuki no Miyakko. One day he noticed among the bamboos a stalk that glowed at the base. He thought this was very strange, and going over to have a look, saw that a light was shining inside the hollow stem. He examined it, and there he found a most lovely little girl about three inches tall. The old man said, "I have discovered you because you were here, among these bamboos I watch over every morning and evening. It must be you are meant to be my child."

He took the little girl in his hands and brought her back home. There he gave the child into the keeping of his old wife, for her to rear. The girl was incomparably beautiful, but still so small they put her in a little basket, the better to care for her.

It often happened afterwards that when the Old Bamboo Cutter gathered bamboo he would find a stalk crammed with gold from joint to joint, and in this way he gradually became very rich.

The child shot up under their loving care. Before three months had passed she stood tall as a grown woman, and her

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parents decided to celebrate her coming of age. Her hair was combed up and they dressed her in trailing skirts. The greatest pains were lavished on her upbringing—they never even allowed her to leave her curtained chamber. This child had a purity of features quite without equal anywhere in the world, and the house was filled with a light that left no corner dark. If ever the old man felt in poor spirits or was in pain, just to look at the child would make the pain stop. All anger too would melt away.

For a long time afterwards the old man went on gathering bamboo, and he became a person of great importance. Now that the girl had attained her full height, a diviner from Mimuroto, Imbe no Akita by name, was summoned to bestow a woman's name on her. Akita called her *Nayotake no Kaguya-hime*, the Shining Princess of the Supple Bamboo. The feast given on the occasion of her name-giving was graced by diversions of every kind and lasted three days. Men and women alike were invited and grandly entertained.

The Suitors

Every man in the realm, whether high or low of rank, could think of nothing but of how much he wanted to win *Kaguya-hime*, or at least to see her. Just to hear the rumors about her made men wild with love. But it was not easy for those who perched on the fence nearby or lurked around her house, or even for those inside, to catch a glimpse of the girl. Unable to sleep peacefully at night, they would go out into the darkness and poke holes in the fence, attempting in this foolish way to get a peep at her. It was from this time that courting a woman came to be known as "nightcrawling."

But all their prowling around the place, where no one showed the least interest in them, was in vain. Even when they made so bold as to address the members of the household, no answer was forthcoming. Many a young noble, refusing to leave the vicinity, spent his nights and days without budging from his post. Suitors of shallower affections decided eventually that this fruitless courtship was a waste of time and ceased their visits.

Five among them, men renowned as connoisseurs of beauty, persisted in their suit. Their attentions never flagged, and they came courting night and day. These were Prince Ishizukuri, Prince Kuramochi, the Minister of the Right Abe no Mimuraji, the Grand Counsellor Ōtomo no Miyuki, and the Middle Counsellor Isonokami no Marotari. Whenever these men heard of any woman who was even moderately good-looking, and the country certainly had many such, they burned to see her; and when they heard about Kaguya-hime they wanted so badly to meet her that they gave up all nourishment and spent their time in brooding. They would go to her house and wander aimlessly about, even though nothing was likely to come of it. They wrote her letters that she did not even deign to answer; they penned odes bewailing their plight. Though they knew it was in vain, they pursued their courtship, undaunted by hindrances, whether the falling snows and the ice of mid-winter or the blazing sun and the thunderbolts of the summer.

One day they called the Bamboo Cutter to them, and each in turn got down on his knees and rubbed his hands, imploring the old man, "Please give me your daughter!"

But the old man replied, "The child was not of my begetting, and she is not obliged to obey my wishes." And so the months and the days went by.

Confronted by this situation, the gentlemen returned to their houses, where, lost in despondent thoughts, they prayed and offered petitions to the gods, either to fulfill their love or else to let them forget Kaguya-hime. But, however they tried, they could not put her from their minds. Despite what the old man had said, they could not believe that he would allow the girl to remain unwedded, and this thought gave them hope.

The old man, observing their ardor, said to Kaguya-hime, "My precious child, I realize you are a divinity in human form, but I have spared no efforts to raise you into such a great, fine lady. Will you not listen to what an old man has to say?"

Kaguya-hime replied, "What request could you make of me to which I would not consent? You say I am a divinity in

human form, but I know nothing of that. I think of you and you alone as my father."

"Oh, how happy you make me!" exclaimed the old man. "I am now over seventy, and I do not know if my end may not come today or tomorrow. In this world it is customary for men and women to marry and for their families then to flourish. Why do you refuse to be wedded?"

Kaguya-hime said, "How could I possibly do such a thing?"

The old man replied, "You are a transformed being, it is true, but you have a woman's body. As long as I am alive, you may, if you choose, remain unmarried, but one day you will be left alone. These gentlemen have been coming here faithfully for months and even years. Listen carefully to what they have to say, and choose one of them as your husband."

"All I can think is that I should certainly regret it if, in spite of my unattractive looks, I married a man without being sure of the depth of his feelings, and he later proved fickle. No matter how distinguished a man he may be, I wouldn't be willing to marry him unless I were sure he was sincere," said Kaguya-hime.

"That's exactly what I myself think," answered the old man. "Now, what must a man's feelings be before you are willing to marry him? All these gentlemen have certainly shown unusual devotion."

Kaguya-hime said, "Shall I tell you the depth of sentiments I require? I am not asking for anything extraordinary. All five men seem to be equally affectionate. How can I tell which of them is the most deserving? If one of the five will show me some special thing I wish to see, I will know his affections are the noblest, and I shall become his wife. Please tell this to the gentlemen if they come again."

"An excellent solution," the old man said approvingly.

Towards sunset the suitors gathered as usual. One played a flute, another sang a song, the third sang from score, and the others whistled and beat time with their fans. The old man appeared while this concert was still in progress. He said, "Your visits during all these months and years have done my humble house too great an honor. I am quite overwhelmed. I

have told Kaguya-hime that my life is now so uncertain I do not know whether today or tomorrow may not be my last day, and I have suggested to her that she consider carefully and choose one of you gentlemen as her husband. She insists, however, on being sure of the depth of your feelings, and that is only proper. She says she will marry whichever of you proves his superiority by showing her some special thing she wishes to see. This is a fine plan, for none of you will then resent her choice." The five men all agreed that it was indeed an excellent suggestion, and the old man went back into the house to report what had happened.

Kaguya-hime declared, "I should like Prince Ishizukuri to obtain for me from India the stone begging-bowl of the Buddha. Prince Kuramochi is to go to the mountain in the Eastern Sea called Hōrai and fetch me a branch of the tree that grows there, with roots of silver and trunk of gold, whose fruits are pearls. The next gentleman is to bring me a robe made of the fur of Chinese fire-rats. I ask Ōtomo, the Grand Counsellor, please to fetch me the jewel that shines five colors, found in a dragon's neck. And Isokami, the Middle Counsellor, should present me with a swallow's easy-delivery charm."

The old man said, "These are indeed difficult tasks. The gifts you ask for are not to be found anywhere in Japan. How shall I break the news of such difficult assignments?"

"What is so difficult about them?" asked Kaguya-hime.

"I'll tell them, at any rate," said the old man and went outside. When he had related what was expected of them, the princes and nobles exclaimed, "Why doesn't she simply say, 'Stay away from my house!'" They all left in disgust.

The Stone Begging-Bowl of the Buddha

Nevertheless, Prince Ishizukuri felt as though his life would not be worth living unless he married the girl, and he reflected, "Is there anything I would not do for her, even if it meant traveling to India to find what she wants?" He realized, however, being a prudent man, how unlikely he was to find the one and only begging-bowl, even if he journeyed all eight

thousand leagues to India. He left word with Kaguya-hime that he was departing that day for India in search of the begging-bowl and remained away for three years. At a mountain temple in Tochi district of the province of Yamato he obtained a bowl that had stood before the image of Binzuru and was pitch-black with soot. He put the bowl in a brocade bag, fastened it to a spray of artificial flowers, and carried it to Kaguya-hime's house. When he presented the bowl, she looked it over suspiciously. Inside she found a note and opened it: "I have worn out my spirits on the roads over sea and mountains; in quest of the stone bowl my tears of blood have flowed."

Kaguya-hime examined the bowl to see if it gave off a light, but there was not so much as a firefly's glimmer. She returned the bowl with the verse, "I hoped that at least the sparkle of the fallen dew would linger within—why did you fetch this bowl from the Mountain of Darkness?"

The Prince threw away the bowl at the gate and replied with this verse, "When it encountered the Mountain of Brightness it lost its light perhaps; I discard the bowl, but shamelessly cling to my hopes." He sent this into the house, but Kaguya-hime no longer deigned to answer. When he discovered she would not even listen to his pleas, he departed, at a loss for words. Because he persisted in his suit even after throwing away the bowl, people have ever since spoken of surprise at a shameless action as being bowled over.

The Jewelled Branch from Paradise

Prince Kuramochi, a man of many devices, requested leave of the court, saying he intended to depart for Tsukushi to take a cure at the hot springs. He sent word at the same time to Kaguya-hime that he was off in search of the jewelled branch. When he left the capital he was accompanied as far as Naniwa by his full staff of retainers, but when he was about to sail from Naniwa he announced he would henceforth travel incognito, taking with him only personal servants instead of his customary large retinue. The others returned to the capital once they had seen him off. The Prince, having convinced

everyone that he had indeed departed, ordered his ship to be rowed back to port three days later.

Prior to his departure the Prince had made detailed arrangements: six metalsmiths, acclaimed as the treasures of the age, were hired; a house that outsiders would have difficulty approaching was built for them; and a furnace enclosed by triple walls was erected. The craftsmen were installed in the house, where they were joined by the Prince himself, who devoted the revenues of all his sixteen domains to the expenses of fashioning the jewelled branch. When completed, it differed in no particle from Kaguya-hime's description. Having carried through his plan so brilliantly, the Prince secretly left for Naniwa with the branch.

He sent word ahead to his household, informing them of his return by ship, and acted as if his journey had been a terrible ordeal. Many people went to Naniwa to welcome him. The jewelled branch was placed in a long wooden chest, covered suitably, and carried ashore. Word soon got around, and rumor had it Prince Kuramochi was bringing back an *udonge* blossom to the capital. When Kaguya-hime heard this, she thought, her heart sinking, "I have been outwitted by this prince."

Just then there was a knocking at the gate, and an attendant proclaimed Prince Kuramochi's arrival. "The Prince has come here without even changing his travelling clothes," he said. The old man, impressed, went out to greet the Prince.

"I have brought back, at the risk of my life, the jewelled branch I was sent for," the Prince announced. "Please show it to Kaguya-hime."

The old man took it inside. The Prince had attached a note to the branch: "Even had it cost me my life, I should not have returned empty-handed, without breaking off the jewelled branch."

While the lady was scanning this verse in dismay, the Old Bamboo Cutter rushed in and declared, "The Prince has brought back from Paradise a jewelled branch that answers exactly the description of the one you requested. What more can you ask of him? He has come directly here in his travelling clothes, not even stopping at his own house. Please ac-

cept the Prince as your husband without further ado." The lady, not saying a word, brooded disconsolately, her head resting on her arm.

"I'm sure there is nothing further to be said at this point," said the Prince, confidently stepping up on the verandah as he spoke. The old man, considering that this was indeed the case, said to Kaguya-hime, "In all Japan there is not another such jewelled branch. How could you refuse him now? Besides, he's a man of splendid character."

She answered, "It was my reluctance to refuse outright what you asked of me, Father, that made me request such impossible things." She found it most exasperating that the Prince should have surprised her in this way by bringing back the branch. The old man busied himself with preparing the nuptial chamber.

The old man asked the Prince, "What was the place like where you found the branch? What a marvellously beautiful and impressive thing it is!"

The Prince replied, "Three years ago, along about the tenth day of the second moon, I boarded ship at Naniwa and put out to sea. I realized that I had no guidance as to the direction I should head, but I told myself that unless I succeeded in my mission, life would not be worth living, and I decided to let the ship be carried ahead at the mercy of the uncertain winds. I reflected that if I died, my struggles would be over; but I was determined that as long as life was left me, I would keep sailing on, in the hope that eventually I might reach the mountain called Hōrai. The ship, drifting on the waves, was rowed farther and farther from Japan. As we moved along, we sometimes encountered waves so rough I thought we would surely sink to the bottom of the sea. Sometimes too we were blown by the winds to strange lands where the people, who looked like demons, attacked and tried to kill us. Sometimes, losing all track of our bearings, we drifted blindly on the sea. Sometimes too our food ran out, and we barely subsisted on roots or shells we took from the sea. And sometimes unspeakably horrible monsters rose in our path, intending to devour us.

"It happened too on our journey, at places where there was

no one to help us, that we were afflicted by sicknesses of every kind, and had nowhere to turn for comfort. We drifted on the sea, letting the ship wander as it pleased. Then, at about eight o'clock in the morning on the five-hundredth day of our journey we faintly perceived in the distance a mountain rising from the sea. All of us aboard the ship strained our eyes for a better look. The mountain soared imposingly over the waves, tall and gracefully shaped. This, I thought, was undoubtedly the place I was looking for; but somehow I felt afraid, and for two or three days I sailed around the mountain, surveying it. One day we noticed a woman dressed like some celestial being emerge from the mountain and walk here and there, dipping water with a silver bowl. I went ashore and asked her the name of the mountain. She answered, 'This is the mountain of Hōrai.' Words cannot describe my delight at hearing these words. I asked her then, 'With whom have I the pleasure of speaking?' 'My name is Ukanruri,' she replied, and so saying went back into the mountain.

"I examined the mountain, but could discover no way to climb it. As I walked around its slopes I saw flowering trees of a kind unknown in this world. Streams of gold, silver and emerald color gushed from the mountain, and spanning them were bridges of many different precious stones. Nearby stood some brilliantly glittering trees. The one whose branch I took was the least impressive, but since it fitted exactly the lady's description, I broke off this spray of blossoms.

"The mountain was incomparably lovely. Nothing in this world even faintly suggests its delights. But now that I had obtained the branch, I was in no mood to dawdle. I boarded ship and, being favored by the wind, returned in a little over four hundred days. Perhaps I owe it to the Buddha's vow to save all mankind that the wind blew me safely to Naniwa. Yesterday I left Naniwa for the capital, and I have come directly here, without so much as changing my brine-soaked clothes."

The old man, having heard the Prince through, sighed and recited the verse: "Through all the generations men have gathered bamboo in mountains and fields, have they ever experienced such unbroken hardships?"

The Prince responded, "My heart which for so long has been prey to anxiety today is at peace." He composed this reply to the old man's verse: "Now that my sleeve has tried today, I am sure I can forget the many pains I have suffered."

Just then a band of six men burst into the garden. One of them held forth a letter inserted in a presentation stick. He said, "I am Ayabe no Uchimaro, an artisan of the Office of Handicrafts. I beg to report that I served this gentleman by making a jewelled branch for him, working for over a thousand days, so devotedly I gave up all normal nourishment. This was no small sacrifice, but he has yet to give me any reward. Please, sir, pay me now so I can take care of my assistants." He proffered the note. The Old Bamboo Cutter shook his head in perplexity, wondering what the workman was talking about. The Prince stood there dumbfounded, looking utterly disconcerted.

Kaguya-hime, hearing what had happened, exclaimed, "Bring me that letter!" She examined it, and this is what it said: "For a thousand days the Prince remained in hiding together with us lowly workmen, and he ordered us to make him a magnificent jewelled branch. He promised he would even give us official posts as our reward. Recently we thought the matter over carefully, and it occurred to us that the branch was surely the one demanded by Kaguya-hime, the Prince's future lady. That is why we have come to this household, to receive our just reward."

"Yes," the men insisted, "We must be paid!" At their cry Kaguya-hime, whose spirits had been steadily darkening as the day drew to a close, suddenly burst into merry laughter. She called the old man to her, and said, "I thought the branch really came from a tree in Paradise, but obviously it is a disgraceful counterfeit. Please send it back at once."

The old man nodded and said, "Now that we know the branch is definitely not genuine, it is a simple matter to return it."

Kaguya-hime's spirits had been completely restored. To the Prince's poem she now sent the reply: "Wondering if your story might be true, I examined the jewelled branch, but it was a sham, like your words." She sent back the branch. The

Old Bamboo Cutter, embarrassed that he had tried so hard to persuade the girl to marry the Prince, shut his eyes, pretending to sleep. The Prince, uncomfortable whether he stood or sat, waited outside uneasily until it grew dark, when he slunk off.

Kaguya-hime summoned the workmen who had presented their grievances. "Happy men!" she cried, and bestowed generous rewards on them. The men were delighted, and left saying, "We got exactly what we wanted." On the way home, however, they were intercepted by Prince Kuramochi, who had them thrashed so severely the blood flowed. Their rewards did them little good, for every last gift was snatched away, and they had to run off for dear life.

The Prince said, "No greater disgrace could befall me in this existence. I have failed to win the girl, and I am mortified to think how the world must despise me." He went off all by himself deep into the mountains. His palace functionaries and personal attendants set off in parties in search of him, but, being unsuccessful, they could only conclude that he probably was dead.

The Prince disappeared for several years, wishing to avoid being seen by his people. It was from this time that people began to speak of someone as being stony-hearted if he astonishes others by trying to pass off as genuine a false stone.

The Robe Made of Fire-Rat Fur

The Minister of the Right Abe no Mimuraji was a man of wealth and the master of a flourishing household. That year a gentleman named Wang Ching arrived aboard a Chinese merchant ship, and Abe no Mimuraji wrote him a letter asking him to buy and send what had been described as a robe of fire-rat fur. He entrusted this letter to Ono no Fusamori, an especially reliable retainer. The man took the letter to Wang Ching and presented it, together with a sum in gold. Wang opened and read the letter, then wrote the reply: "Robes made from the fur of fire-rats are not obtainable in my country. I have indeed heard of such things, but have yet to see one. If any really existed, surely someone would have

brought one to China. This will entail some very difficult negotiations. However, on the chance that one may have been imported into India, I shall make enquiries at the houses of the rich men there. If my search proves unsuccessful, I shall return the money with your servant."

The Chinese ship left for China, only presently to return to Japan. The Minister, learning that Fusamori was in Japan and on his way to the capital, sent a swift-footed horse to meet him. Fusamori mounted the horse and rode from Tsukushi to the capital in a bare seven days. He brought a letter from Wang Ching: "I have managed with great difficulty, by sending my men everywhere, to acquire the robe of fire-rat fur I am now forwarding. A robe of this fur has never been easy to obtain, whether now or in the past. I was informed that long ago a great Indian priest had brought one to China, and that it was now preserved in a mountain temple to the west. Eventually, with the assistance of the authorities, I was able to purchase it. The officials told my man that the money you sent was insufficient, and I was therefore obliged to add some of my own. I should appreciate it if you would kindly remit fifty ounces of gold by the return voyage of the ship. Please return the robe if you are unwilling to send the money."

When the Minister read these words he exclaimed, "How can he suggest such a thing? He's only asking for a trifle more money, after all. Of course I'll give it to him. How wonderful that he found the robe and sent it to me!" He made a deep bow in the direction of China.

The box containing the robe was inlaid with precious stones and glittered resplendently. The fur itself was a bluish-black, and the hair-tips shone with a golden light. This obviously was a treasure of incomparable beauty. Its beauty indeed was even more remarkable than its vaunted imperviousness to flame. "I can see why Kaguya-hime should have wanted it so," said the Minister. "What a magnificent robe it is!" He placed the robe in a box, attached the box to a branch, and beautified himself with great care, imagining he would spend that very night at her house. He composed a poem to take along: "I have burnt with the flames of boundless love, but today I wear with dry sleeves the fur robe that does not burn in fire."

The Minister took the box to Kaguya-hime's gate and waited there. The Bamboo Cutter came out, accepted the gift, and showed it to Kaguya-hime. "What a lovely robe it is!" she said as she examined it, "But I still cannot be sure it is the genuine fur."

The Bamboo Cutter answered, "That may be so, but I'll invite him in anyway. In all the world there is not another such fur robe. You'd best accept it as genuine. Don't make people suffer so!" He invited the Minister inside and seated him.

The old woman, seeing the Minister ushered to the place of honor, was also convinced in her heart that this time the girl would be wed. The old man had grieved that Kaguya-hime was still single and worried himself over finding a suitable husband for her, but she was so resolutely opposed that he naturally had never tried to force her.

Kaguya-hime said to the old man, "If this fur robe does not burn when it is put in fire, I shall admit that it is genuine and do what is required of me. You say you have never seen its like and that you have no doubt but that it is genuine, but I should like to test it in fire."

"That is quite reasonable," said the old man, and so informed the Minister.

The latter replied, "I secured this fur robe, which was not even to be had in China, with the greatest difficulty. What doubt could there be? All the same, please do test it in the flames at once."

Kaguya-hime asked someone to place it in the fire, where it burned brightly. "Just as I thought," said Kaguya-hime, "The robe was an imitation." The Minister, seeing this, turned the color of leaves of grass. Kaguya-hime was enchanted. She wrote a poem in response to the Minister's, and put it in the box: "Had I known it would burn, leaving not a trace, I should not have worried so, but kept the fur robe away from the flames." The Minister departed.

People crowded around the old man's house and asked, "We hear that Minister Abe has brought a robe of fire-rat fur and is living with the lady. Is he here now?" Someone answered, "When they put the fur into the fire it burst into flames, so Kaguya-hime won't marry him." Those who

heard the story transmitted it, and ever since people have said that when a plan is not carried out it falls into Abe-yance.

The Jewel in the Dragon's Neck

Ōtomo no Miyuki, the Grand Counsellor, called together all the members of his household and announced, "A dragon carries a shining five-colored jewel in his neck. Anyone who can get one for me will have whatever he desires."

His men, hearing these words, said, "Your lordship's commands are exceedingly gracious. But such jewels are not easy to come by, and how could we possibly get one from a dragon's neck?"

The Grand Counsellor retorted, "Servants should try to fulfill their master's orders, even if at the risk of their lives. I am not asking for something from India or China that cannot be found in Japan. Dragons are constantly rising from the sea and descending from the mountains in this country. What makes you think it is so difficult?"

"In that case," said the men, "We shall say no more. However difficult it may be, we will go and search for the jewel as you command."

The Grand Counsellor smiled. "You have acquired quite a reputation for being faithful servants of your master. How could you disobey my orders?" He sent them off in search of the jewel in the dragon's neck, stripping his palace of all its silk, cotton, and copper coins to provide them with the means of paying for their food along the way.

"Until you return we shall refrain from eating animal food," he promised, "But don't come back without the jewel!"

The servants departed, each with his instructions. "He told us not to return without the jewel from the dragon's neck—let's just hie ourselves off in whatever direction our feet happen to take us. What a crazy thing to ask of us!" grumbled the servants. They divided up the valuables they had been given; then some returned to their own homes while others set off for places they had long wished to visit. All abused the Grand Counsellor for having issued such unreasonable orders, impossible to execute even if they came from a father or master.

The Grand Counsellor next announced: "I should be exposing myself to ridicule if I asked Kaguya-hime to live here without even altering the place." He proceeded to build a magnificent house for her, its walls lacquered and sprinkled with gold, and its roof thatched with silken threads of many colors. The rooms were furnished with indescribable splendor, and paintings on figured damask hung in each alcove. The Grand Counsellor, certain that Kaguya-hime would become his bride, set his concubines to work making preparations for the wedding and, neglecting his first wife completely, spent his days and nights alone.

The Counsellor waited every day for the men he had despatched, but no news had come by the New Year. In his impatience, he disguised himself and went in great secret to the region of Naniwa, accompanied by only two retainers. There he made enquiries: "Have you heard anything about the men of the Grand Counsellor Ōtomo, who sailed off to slay a dragon and take the jewel in its neck?"

"What a strange story!" replied a boatman with a laugh "We have no boats here that do that kind of work."

The Grand Counsellor thought, "What an irresponsible answer for a boatman to give! He doesn't know who I am. That's why he talks that way." He reflected a while, then said to himself, "I am strong enough with my bow to shoot dead any dragon that shows itself. I'll get the jewel for myself. I won't wait for these rascals to come straggling home." He boarded a ship and sailed round from one arm of the sea to the next, until he reached the distant ocean off Tsukushi.

What happened then? A terrible gale began to blow, everything went dark around them, and a storm tossed the ship helplessly hither and thither, until they lost all track of direction, and it seemed that the wind would surely blow the ship out into the middle of the ocean. The waves lashed again and again at the ship, sucking it down, and lightning flashed almost on top of the vessel. The Grand Counsellor cried out in utter bewilderment, "I've never been in such a horrible predicament before. What will become of me?"

The steersman replied, "In all the years I have been sailing the seas, I've never seen such a terrible storm. If the ship doesn't go down, it's sure to be struck by lightning. And even

if by some good fortune the gods spare our lives, we'll probably be blown all the way to the South Seas. It's all because I serve such a crazy master that I must die like a fool!" He wept.

The Grand Counsellor, hearing these words, cried, in between violent bouts of vomiting, "When aboard ship I trust in what the steersman says as in a great mountain. Why do you say such disheartening things?"

The steersman answered, "How should I know how to help you? I'm not a god. It's all because you were looking for a dragon to kill that the wind has been blowing and the waves raging. On top of everything else, we're even getting thunderbolts rained down on our heads. This storm has been blown up by a dragon's breath. Make your prayers to the gods, and don't delay!"

"A good suggestion," said the Grand Counsellor. "God of steersmen, hear my words! I intended in my foolishness to kill a dragon. But from now on I'll never disturb so much as the tip of a dragon's hair." He bellowed this assurance in a loud voice, now standing, now sitting, shouting and weeping all the while. Gradually the thunder abated, perhaps because he had repeated these words at least a thousand times. Lightning still flashed a little, and the wind blew hard as ever, but the steersman commented, "You see—the storm was a dragon's doing. The wind now is favoring us. It's blowing us in the right direction." The Grand Counsellor paid no attention to these words.

The wind blew for three or four days and brought them back to land. The sailors recognized the coast as Akashi in Harima. The Grand Counsellor, however, imagining that they must have been driven ashore somewhere in the South Seas, heaved a great sigh and lay flat on his face. The men aboard the ship reported to the government office on shore, and the local officials went to call on the Grand Counsellor. Even then he was unable to rise, but continued to lie on his face at the bottom of the ship. They spread a mat for him in a pine field, and unloaded him from the ship. Then, for the first time, he realized that he was not in the South Seas, and with great difficulty managed to stand. He looked like a man with

some horrible sickness—his belly bulged out grotesquely and he seemed to have plums for eyes. The officials could not hold back their smiles when they looked at him.

The Grand Counsellor gave orders to the officials to have a sedan chair prepared for him, and he was borne home, groaning all the way. When he arrived, the men he had sent out, who had somehow got word of his return, appeared and informed him, “We couldn’t get the jewel in the dragon’s neck, and that’s why we didn’t come back to serve you. We’ve returned now that you’ve found out how difficult it is to get the jewel. We’re sure you won’t punish us too severely.”

The Grand Counsellor sat up. “You did well not to bring one back. Dragons belong to the same species as the thunder, and if you had tried to capture the jewel, many of you would have been killed. And if you had actually caught a dragon, it certainly would have meant the death of me. I’m glad you didn’t catch one! That cursed thief of a Kaguya-hime was trying to kill us! I’ll never go near her house again. And don’t you go wandering around there either!” He bestowed on the men who had failed to bring back the jewel what little remained of his fortune. When his first wife, from whom he had separated, heard about this, she laughed until her sides ached. The roof that had been thatched with silken threads was pillaged completely by kites and rooks, to line their nests.

People asked, “Has the Grand Counsellor Ōtomo gone off to find the jewel in a dragon’s neck?” “No,” said others, “Where his eyes should be he has stuck stones that look like plums.” “Oh,” they answered, “that’s plumb foolish.” And from that time on people spoke of any ill-starred venture as being plumb foolish.

The Easy-Delivery Charm of the Swallows

The Middle Counsellor Isonokami no Marotari gave orders to the men in his employ to report if any swallows were building nests. “Yes, sir,” they said, “But why do you need this information?” He answered, “I intend to get the easy-delivery charm that a swallow carries.”

The men said variously, “I’ve killed many swallows in my

time, but I've never seen anything of that description in a swallow's belly." "How do you suppose a swallow manages to pull out the charm just when it's about to give birth?" "It keeps the charm hidden, and if any man gets a glimpse of it, it disappears."

Still another man said, "Swallows are building nests in all the holes along the eaves of the Palace Kitchen. If you send some dependable men there and set up perches from which they can observe the swallows, there are so many swallows that one of them is sure to be giving birth. That will give your men the chance to grab the charm."

The Middle Counsellor was delighted. "How perfectly extraordinary!" he said, "I had never noticed! Thank you for a most promising suggestion." He ordered twenty dependable men to the spot, and stationed them on lookout perches built for their task. From his mansion he sent a steady stream of messengers asking if the men had successfully obtained the easy-delivery charm.

The swallows, terrified by all the people climbing up to the roof, did not return to their nests. When the Middle Counsellor learned of this, he was at a loss what to do now. Just at this point an old man named Kuratsumaro who worked in the Palace Kitchen was heard to remark, "I have a plan for his Excellency if he wishes to get a swallow's easy-delivery charm." He was at once ushered into the presence of the Middle Counsellor and seated directly before him.

Kuratsumaro said, "You are using clumsy methods to get the charm, and you'll never succeed in that way. The twenty men on their lookout perches are making such a racket that the swallows are much too frightened to come close. You should tear down the perches and dismiss all the men. One man only, a dependable man, should be kept in readiness inside an open-work basket that has a rope attached to it. As soon as a swallow starts to lay an egg, the man in the basket should be hoisted up with the rope. Then he can quickly grab the charm. That is your best plan."

"An excellent plan indeed," said the Middle Counsellor. The perches were dismantled and the men all returned to the palace. The Counsellor asked Kuratsumaro, "How will we

know when the swallow is about to give birth, so the man can be hoisted up in time?"

Kuratsumaro answered, "When a swallow is about to give birth it raises its tail and circles around seven times. As it is completing its seventh turn you should hoist the basket immediately and the man can snatch the charm."

The Counsellor was overjoyed to hear Kuratsumaro's words. "How wonderful to have my prayers granted!" he exclaimed, "And to think you're not even in my service!" He removed his cloak and offered it to the old man. "Come tonight to the Palace Kitchen," he said, dismissing him.

When it grew dark the Middle Counsellor went to the Kitchen. He observed that swallows were indeed building nests and circling the place with lifted tails, exactly as Kuratsumaro had described. A man was put in a basket and hoisted up, but when he put his hand into the swallow's nest he called down, "There's nothing here!"

"That's because you aren't searching in the proper way!" the Counsellor angrily retorted. "Is there nobody competent here? I'll have to go up there myself." He climbed into the basket and was hoisted up. He peered into a nest and saw a swallow with its tail lifted circling about furiously. He at once stretched out his arm and felt in the nest. His fingers touched something flat. "I've got it! Lower me now; I've done it myself!" he cried. His men gathered round, but in their eagerness to lower him quickly they pulled too hard, and the rope snapped. The Middle Counsellor plunged down, landing on his back atop a kitchen cauldron.

His men rushed to him in consternation and lifted him in their arms. He lay motionless, showing the whites of his eyes. The men drew some water and got him to swallow a little. At length he regained consciousness, and they lowered him by the hands and feet from the top of the cauldron. When they at last felt they could ask him how he was, he answered in a faint voice, "My head seems a little clearer, but I can't move my legs. But I am happy anyway that I managed to get the easy-delivery charm. Light a torch and bring it here. I want to see what the charm looks like." He raised his head and opened his hand only to discover he was clenching some old droppings

the swallows had left. "Alas," he cried, "It was all to no avail!" Ever since that time people have said a project that goes contrary to expectations "lacks charm."

When the Middle Counsellor realized he had failed to obtain the charm, his spirits took a decided turn for the worse. His men laid him inside the lid of a Chinese chest and carried him home. He could not be placed inside his carriage because his back had been broken.

The Middle Counsellor attempted to keep people from learning he had been injured because of a childish escapade. Under the strain of this worry he became all the weaker. It bothered him more that people might hear of his fiasco and mock him, than that he had failed to secure the charm. His anxiety grew worse each day, until he felt in the end it would be preferable to die of illness in a normal manner than lose his reputation.

Kaguya-hime, hearing of his unfortunate condition, sent a poem of enquiry: "The years pass, but the waves do not return to the pines of Suminoe, where I wait in vain; you have failed to find the charm, I am told, is it true?"

He asked that her poem be read to him. Then he lifted his head very feebly, barely able to write in great pain while someone else held the paper: "My efforts were in vain, and now I am about to die in despair; but will you not save my life?" With these words he expired. Kaguya-hime was rather touched.

From this time something slightly pleasurable has been said to have a modicum of charm.

The Imperial Hunt

The Emperor, learning of Kaguya-hime's unrivaled beauty, said to a maid of honor, Nakatomi no Fusako by name, "Please go and discover for me what kind of woman Kaguya-hime is, this beauty who has brought so many men to ruin and refuses to marry."

Fusako, obedient to his command, departed. When she arrived at the Bamboo Cutter's house the old woman deferen-

tially showed her in. The maid of honor said, "I have been ordered by His Majesty to ascertain whether Kaguya-hime is as beautiful as people say. That is why I am here now."

"I shall tell her," said the old woman and went inside. "Please," she urged Kaguya-hime, "Hurry out and meet the Emperor's messenger."

Kaguya-hime replied, "How can I appear before her when I am not in the least attractive?"

"Don't talk nonsense! Do you dare to show such disrespect to someone sent here by the Emperor?"

"It doesn't make me feel especially grateful to think the Emperor might wish to summon me," answered Kaguya-hime. She showed no sign of relenting and meeting the lady. The old woman had always considered Kaguya-hime as being no different from a child she had borne herself, but when the girl spoke so coldly, it much embarrassed her, and she could not reprimand Kaguya-hime as she would have liked.

The old woman returned to the maid of honor and said, "I must apologize, but the girl is terribly obstinate and refuses to see you."

The maid of honor said, "I was ordered by His Majesty to verify her appearance without fail. How can I return to the Palace without seeing her? Do you think it proper for anyone living in this country to be allowed to disobey a royal command? Please do not let her act so unreasonably!" She intended these words to shame Kaguya-hime, but when the latter was informed, she refused all the more vehemently to comply. "If I am disobeying a royal command, let them execute me without delay," she declared.

The maid of honor returned to the Palace and reported what had happened. The Emperor listened and said merely, "You can see she's quite capable of causing the deaths of a great many men." He seemed to have given up all thought of summoning Kaguya-hime into his service, but he still had his heart set on her, and refused to accept defeat at her hands. He sent for the old man and stated, "I want this Kaguya-hime you have at your place. Word has reached me of the beauty of her face and figure, and I sent my messenger to look her over, but she returned unsuccessful, unable to obtain so much as a

glimpse of the girl. Did you bring her up to be so disrespectful?"

The old man humbly replied, "The girl absolutely refuses to serve at Court. I am quite at a loss what to do about her. But I'll go back home and report your Majesty's command."

The Emperor asked, "Why should a child you have raised with your own hands refuse to do what you wish? If you present the girl for service here, you can be quite sure I will reward you with court rank."

The old man returned home, overjoyed. He related this conversation to Kaguya-hime, concluding, "That was what the Emperor told me. Are you still unwilling to serve him?"

Kaguya-hime answered, "I absolutely refuse to serve at the Court. If you force me, I'll simply disappear. It may win you a court rank, but it will mean my death."

"Never do such a dreadful thing!" cried the old man. "What use would position or rank be to me if I couldn't behold my child? But why are you so reluctant to serve at the Court? Would it really kill you?"

"If you still think I am lying, send me into service at the Court and see if I don't die. Many men have showed me most unusual affection, but all of them in vain. If I obey the Emperor's wishes, no sooner than he expresses them, I shall feel ashamed how people will consider my coldness to those other men."

The old man replied, "I don't care about anyone else. The only thing that disturbs me is the danger to your life. I'll report that you are still unwilling to serve." He went to the Palace and informed the Emperor, "In humble obedience to Your Majesty's command, I attempted to persuade the child to enter your service, but she told me that if I forced her to serve in the Palace, it would surely cause her death. This child was not born of my body. I found her long ago in the mountains. That is why her ways are not like those of ordinary people."

The Emperor commented, "She must be a transformed being. There's no hope, then, of having her serve me, but at least I should like somehow to get a glimpse of her."

"I wonder how this could be arranged," said the old man.

The Emperor said, "I understand, Miyakkomaro, your house is near the mountains. How would it be if, under pretext of staging an imperial hunt, I stopped by for a look at her?"

"That is an excellent plan," said the old man. "If Your Majesty should happen to call at a time when she does not expect a visitor, you can probably see her." The Emperor at once set a date for the hunt.

During the course of the hunt the Emperor entered Kaguya-hime's house and saw there a woman so lovely she shed a radiance around her. He thought, this must be Kaguya-hime, and approached. She fled into the adjoining room, but the Emperor caught her by the sleeve. She covered her face, but his first glimpse was enough to convince him that she was a peerless beauty. "I won't let you go!" he cried. But when he attempted to take her away with him, Kaguya-hime declared, "If I had been born on earth I would have served you. But if you try to force me to go with you, you will find you cannot."

The Emperor said, "Why can't I? I'll take you with me!" He summoned his palanquin, but at that instant Kaguya-hime suddenly dissolved into a shadow. The Emperor realized to his dismay and disappointment that she was indeed no ordinary mortal. He said, "I shall not insist any longer that you come with me. But please return to your former shape. Just one look at you and I shall go." Kaguya-hime resumed her original appearance.

The Emperor was still too entranced with Kaguya-hime's beauty to stifle his feelings, and he displayed his pleasure with the old man for having brought about the meeting. Miyakkomaro, for his part, tendered a splendid banquet for the Emperor's officers. The Emperor was bitterly disappointed to return to the Palace without Kaguya-hime, and as he left the Bamboo Cutter's house he felt as though his soul remained behind. After he had entered his palanquin he sent this verse to Kaguya-hime: "As I go back to the Palace my spirits lag; I turn back, I hesitate, because of Kaguya-hime, who defies me and remains behind."

To this she wrote in reply, "How could one who has lived

her life in a house overgrown with weeds dare to look upon a jewelled Palace?"

The Emperor felt there was less reason than ever to leave when he saw this poem, but since he could not spend the night with Kaguya-hime, he had no choice but to return. When he saw again the Palace ladies who usually waited on him they seemed unworthy even to appear in Kaguya-hime's presence. Indeed, the very ladies he had always considered more beautiful than other women, when compared to Kaguya-hime seemed scarcely worthy of the name of human beings. He ceased visiting his consorts, finding no pleasure in their company. He wrote letters only to Kaguya-hime, and her answers were by no means unkind. He used also to send her poems attached to flowers or branches that struck him as especially attractive.

The Celestial Robe of Feathers

They passed some three years in this way, each consoling the other. At the beginning of the next spring Kaguya-hime seemed more pensive than usual as she watched the Moon rise in all its splendor. Some one nearby admonished her, "People should avoid staring the Moon in the face." But when no one was around, Kaguya-hime would often gaze at the Moon and weep bitterly. At the time of the full moon of the seventh month she sat outside, seemingly lost in thought.

Her maidservants informed the Bamboo Cutter: "Kaguya-hime has always looked with deep emotion at the Moon, but she has seemed rather strange of late. She must be terribly upset over something. Please keep an eye on her."

The old man asked Kaguya-hime, "What makes you look so pensively at the Moon?"

She answered, "When I look at the Moon the world seems lonely and sad. What else would there be to worry me?"

He went over to Kaguya-hime and looked at her face. She definitely appeared melancholy. He asked, "My dear one, what are you thinking of? What worries you?"

"I am not worried about anything. But everything seems so depressing."

"You shouldn't look at the Moon," the old man said. "Whenever you do, you always seem so upset."

"How could I go on living if I didn't look at the Moon?" Each night, as the Moon rose, she would sit outside, immersed in thought. On dark moonless nights she seemed to emerge from her reverie, but with the reappearance of the Moon she would sometimes sigh and weep. Her maids whispered to one another, "There really does seem to be something disturbing her," but no one, not even her parents, knew what it was.

One moonlight night towards the middle of the eighth month Kaguya-hime, sitting outside, suddenly burst into a flood of tears. She now wept without caring whether or not people saw. Her parents, noticing this, asked in alarm what was troubling her. Kaguya-hime answered, still weeping, "I have intended to tell you for a long time, but I was so sure I would make you unhappy that I have kept silent all this while. But I can be silent no more. I will tell you everything. I am not a creature of this world. I came from the Palace of the Moon to this world because of an obligation incurred in a former life. Now the time has come when I must return. On the night of the full moon people from my old country will come for me, and I will have no choice but to go. I was heartbroken to think how unhappy this news would make you, and that is why I have been grieving ever since this spring." She wept copiously.

The old man cried, "What's that you say? I found you in a stick of bamboo when you were no bigger than a poppy seed, and I have brought you up until now you stand as tall as I. Who is going to take my child away? Do you think I'll let them?" He added, "If they do, it will kill me." His distraught weeping was really unbearable to behold.

Kaguya-hime said, "I have a father and mother who live in the City of the Moon. When I came here from my country I said it would be just for a short while, but already I have spent many years in this land. I have tarried among you, without thinking of my parents on the Moon, and I have become accustomed to your ways. Now that I am about to return I feel no great joy, but only a terrible sadness. And yet though it is

not by my choice, I must go." They both wept uncontrollably. Her maids, who had been in her service for years, thought how unspeakable parting would be, and how much they would miss her noble and lively disposition, to which they had grown so familiar. They refused all nourishment and grieved no less than the others.

When the Emperor learned what had occurred, he sent a messenger to the Bamboo Cutter's house. The old man went out to receive him, weeping profusely. His beard had turned white from sorrow, his back was bent, and his eyes were swollen. He was just fifty this year, but his troubles seemed to have aged him suddenly. The imperial messenger transmitted the Emperor's words: "I am informed that you have been afflicted by a grave misfortune—is it true?"

The Bamboo Cutter, weeping, answered the message, "On the night of the full moon men are coming from the City of the Moon to fetch Kaguya-hime. I am deeply honored by His Majesty's kind enquiry, and beg him to send soldiers here on that night, to catch anyone who may arrive from the Moon."

The messenger departed and, after reporting to the Emperor on the old man's condition, repeated his request. The Emperor said, "If I, who had but a single glimpse of Kaguya-hime, cannot put her from my thoughts, what must it be like for her parents, who are used to seeing her day and night, to lose her?"

On the fifteenth, the day of the full moon, the Emperor issued orders to the different guards headquarters, and, designating as his official envoy the Junior Commandant of the Palace Guards, Takano no Okuni, sent a force of some two thousand men from the Six Headquarters to the Bamboo Cutter's house. No sooner did they arrive than a thousand men posted themselves on the wall and a thousand on the roof. Together with the numerous members of the household they formed a defense that left no openings. The defenders were equipped with bows and arrows, and inside the main house the womenfolk were stationed, guarding it.

The old woman sat in the strong-room of the house, holding Kaguya-hime in her arms. The old man, having tightly

barred the door, stood on guard at the entrance. He declared, "Do you think anybody, even if he comes from the Moon, is going to break through our defences?" He called to the roof, "Shoot to kill if you see anything flying in the sky, no matter how small!"

The guards answered, "With defenses as strong as ours we're sure we can shoot down even a mosquito. We'll expose its body as a warning to the others." Their words greatly reassured the old man.

Kaguya-hime said, "No matter how you lock me up and try to guard me, you won't be able to resist the men from the Moon. You won't be able to use your weapons on them. Even if you shut me up in this room, when they come everything will open before them. Resist them though you may, when they come even the bravest man will lose heart."

"If anyone comes after you, I'll tear out his eyes with my long nails," cried old man. "I'll grab him by the hair and throw him to ground. I'll put him to shame by exposing his behind for all the officers to see!" He shouted with anger.

"Don't talk in such a loud voice," cautioned Kaguya-hime. "It would be shocking if the men on the roof heard you. I am very sorry to leave you without ever having expressed my gratitude for all your kindnesses. It makes me sad to think that fate did not permit us to remain together for long, and I must soon depart. Surely you know it will not be easy for me to leave without ever having shown in the least my devotion to you, my parents. When I have gone outside and have sat looking at the Moon I have always begged for just one more year with you, but my wish was refused. That was what made me so unhappy. It breaks my heart to leave you after bringing you such grief. The people of the Moon are extremely beautiful, and they never grow old. Nor have they any worries. Yet, I am not all happy to be returning. I know I shall miss you and keep wishing I could be looking after you when you are old and helpless." She spoke in tears.

"Don't talk of such heartrending things!" the old man exclaimed. "No matter how beautiful those people may be, I won't let them stand in my way." His tone was bitter.

By now the evening had passed. About midnight the area

of the house was suddenly illuminated by a light more dazzling than that of high noon, a light as brilliant as ten full moons put together, so bright one could see the pores of a man's skin. Then down from the heavens men came riding on clouds, and arrayed themselves at a height some five feet above the ground. The guards inside and outside the house, seemingly victims of some supernatural spell, quite lost their will to resist. At length they plucked up their courage and tried to ready their bows and arrows, but the strength had gone from their hands, and their bodies were limp. Some valiant men among them, with a great effort, tried to shoot their bows, but the arrows glanced off harmlessly in all directions. Unable to fight boldly, like soldiers, they could only watch on stupefied.

Words cannot describe the beauty of the raiment worn by the men who hovered in the air. With them they had brought a flying chariot covered by a parasol of gauzy silk. One among them, apparently their king, called out, "Miyakkomaro, come here!" The old man, who had assumed such an air of defiance, prostrated himself before the stranger, feeling as if he were in a drunken stupor. The king said, "You childish old man! We sent the young lady down into the world for a short while, in return for some trifling good deeds you had performed, and for many years we have bestowed riches on you, until you are now like a different man. Kaguya-hime was obliged to live for a time in such humble surroundings because of a sin she had committed in the past. The term of her punishment is over, and we have come, as you can see, to escort her home. No matter how you weep and wail, old man, you cannot detain her. Send her forth at once!"

"I have been watching over Kaguya-hime for more than twenty years," the old man answered. "You speak of her having come down into this world for 'a short while.' It makes me wonder if you are not talking about some other Kaguya-hime living in a different place." He added, "Besides, the Kaguya-hime I have here is suffering from a serious illness and cannot leave her room."

No answer met his words. Instead, the king guided the flying chariot to the roof, where he called out, "Kaguya-hime!

Why have you lingered such a long time in this filthy place?" The door of the strong room flew open, and the lattice-work shutters opened of their own accord. The old woman had been clutching Kaguya-hime in her arms, but now the girl freed herself and stepped outside. The old woman, unable to restrain her, could only look up to heaven and weep.

Kaguya-hime approached the Bamboo Cutter, who lay prostrate, weeping in his bewilderment. "It is not by my own inclination that I leave you now," she said. "Please at least watch as I ascend into the sky."

"How can I watch you go when it makes me so sad? You are abandoning me to go up to Heaven, not caring what may happen to me. Take me with you!" He threw himself down, weeping.

Kaguya-hime was at a loss what to do. She said, "Before I go I shall write a letter for you. If ever you long for me, take out the letter and read it." In tears she wrote these words: "Had I but been born in this world I should have stayed with you and never caused you any grief. To leave this world and part from you is quite contrary to my wishes. Please think of this cloak, that I leave with you, as a memento of me. On nights when the Moon shines in the sky, gaze at it well. Now that I am about to forsake you, I feel as though I must fall from the sky, pulled back to this world by my longing for you."

Some of the celestial beings had brought boxes with them. One contained a robe of feathers, another the elixir of immortality. "Please take some of the elixir in this jar," said a celestial being to Kaguya-hime. "You must be feeling unwell after the things you have had to eat in this dirty place." He offered her the elixir and Kaguya-hime tasted a little. Then, thinking she might leave a little as a remembrance of herself, she started to wrap some of the elixir in the cloak she had discarded, when a celestial being prevented her. He took the robe of feathers from its box and attempted to throw it over her shoulders, but Kaguya-hime cried out. "Wait just a moment! They say that once you put on this robe your heart changes, and there are still a few words I must say." She wrote another letter.

The celestial beings called impatiently, "It's late!"

"Don't talk so unreasonably!" exclaimed Kaguya-hime. With perfect serenity she gave the letter to someone for delivery to the Emperor. She showed no signs of agitation. The letter said: "Although you graciously deigned to send many people to detain me here, my escorts have come and will not be denied. Now they will take me with them, to my bitter regret and sorrow. I am sure you must find it quite incomprehensible, but it weighs heaviest on my heart that you may consider my stubborn refusal to obey your commands an act of disrespect." To the above she added the verse: "Now that the moment has come to put on the robe of feathers, how longingly I recall my lord!" Kaguya-hime attached to the letter some elixir of immortality from the jar and, summoning the commander of the guards, directed him to offer it to the Emperor. A celestial being took the gift from her hands and passed it to the commander. No sooner had the commander accepted the elixir than the celestial being put the robe of feathers on Kaguya-hime. At once she lost all recollection of the pity and grief she had felt for the old man. No cares afflict anyone who once puts on this robe, and Kaguya-hime, in all tranquillity, climbed into her chariot and ascended into the sky, accompanied by a retinue of a hundred celestial beings.

The old man and woman shed bitter tears, but to no avail. When her letter was read to them, they cried, "Why should we cling to our lives? For whose sake? All is useless now." They refused to take medicine, and never left their sick-beds again.

The commander returned to the Palace with his men. He reported in detail the reasons why he and his men had failed with their weapons to prevent Kaguya-hime from departing. He also presented the jar of elixir with the letter attached. The Emperor felt much distressed when he opened the letter and read Kaguya-hime's words. He refused all nourishment, and permitted no entertainments in his presence.

Later, the Emperor summoned his ministers and great nobles and asked them which mountain was closest to Heaven. One man replied, "The mountain in the province of Suruga. It is near both to the capital and to Heaven." The Emperor

thereupon wrote the poem: "What use is it, this elixir of immortality, to one who floats in tears because he cannot meet her again?"

He gave the poem and the jar containing the elixir to a messenger with the command that he take them to the summit of the mountain in Suruga. He directed that the letter and the jar be placed side by side, set on fire, and allowed to be consumed in the flames. The men, obeying this command, climbed the mountain, taking with them a great many soldiers. Ever since they burnt the elixir of immortality on the summit, people have called the mountain by the name Fuji, meaning immortal. Even now the smoke is still said to rise into the clouds.